

Sean Pelillo - Servant leadership - BUAD 405

For this project I chose to research Tim Tebow as my example of a servant leader. Most people know Tim Tebow as the Heisman-winning quarterback who famously wore his faith on his sleeve (literally, on his eye black). But if you look at his life today, football is really just the prologue. He's transitioned from being a professional athlete into a full-time humanitarian. Through the Tim Tebow Foundation, he's dedicated his life to advocating for people who are often pushed to the fringes, children with profound medical needs, orphans, and victims of human trafficking. He's become someone who has consistently uses his fame as a tool to serve others.

When you look at the 7 Pillars framework by Sipe and Frick, Tebow's life matches up remarkably well:

- **Person of Character:** In a world where many leaders have a "public persona" and a different "private reality," Tebow is known for his consistency. Whether he's on a camera or in a hospital room, his integrity and core values remain the same.
- **Puts People First:** You see this most clearly in "Night to Shine." It's a global prom for people with special needs. Instead of hosting galas for donors, he spends his energy creating a night where people who are usually ignored feel like royalty.
- **Skilled Communicator:** Tebow is a gifted speaker, but servant leadership is also about listening. He's known for spending hours listening to the stories of the families he serves, ensuring that his foundation's work actually meets their real-world needs.
- **Has Foresight:** He understood early on that his time in the NFL wouldn't last forever. He had the foresight to build a massive service infrastructure while he was at the height of his fame, ensuring his impact would continue long after he hung up his jersey.
- **Compassionate Collaborator:** He doesn't try to do everything alone. His foundation works with thousands of local churches and global organizations. He's more interested in the mission succeeding than his name being the only one on the letterhead.
- **Systems Thinker:** He doesn't just treat symptoms, but he looks at systems. For example, in the Philippines, he didn't just fund one-off surgeries, he helped build the Tebow CURE Hospital to create a permanent healthcare system for children in need.
- **Leads with Moral Authority:** Tebow leads through sacrifice and "walking the walk." He often says that "service is the greatest form of leadership," and he lives that out by consistently choosing the needs of others over his own comfort or career path.

Looking at some of his critics, a common critique of Tebow is his outspokenness about his Christian faith. In a diverse business or secular environment, leading with such a profound faith can sometimes make people who don't share those beliefs uncomfortable. Additionally,

because he's so high-profile, some skeptics have wondered if his service is a way to maintain his "brand" now that his playing days are over.

However, what makes him a true servant leader in my eyes is his persistence. Usually, when an athlete's career ends, their charity work fades too. Tebow did the opposite. He leaned in harder. He's shown that he's willing to be criticized or even mocked for his convictions as long as it helps the people he's serving. That kind of thick skin for the sake of others is the hallmark of a servant's heart.

Looking at Tebow's example as I head into the business world, a few things really stick with me: 1) Influence is a Loan: Tebow treats his fame like a loan that he has to pay back with service. In business, if I gain a position of power, I should view it as a tool to help my team, not a throne to sit on. 2) The "Bottom Line" Includes People: It's easy to get buried in spreadsheets, but Tebow reminds me that the most important "ROI" is the impact you have on the people around you. 3) Resilience Matters: You won't always be the most popular person in the room when you stand up for your values. Tebow shows that you can be a "nice guy" and a "servant" while still being incredibly driven and resilient.

Sources

Tim Tebow Foundation. (n.d.). *Our Mission and History*. <https://www.timtebowfoundation.org>